public, resistance to its results came from various quarters, most vocally from Karnataka's two biggest caste groups—the Veerashaiva-Lingayats and Vokkaligas—who cast doubt on the accuracy of the exercise that covered 59.8 million people, or 94 per cent of Karnataka's estimated 63.5 million citizens. A purported 'leak' in 2016 of the numerical strength of major communities had aggravated their fears of an undercount, causing a furore. The actual survey data, however, did not make it to the open then—in fact, its report was never submitted to the government. It was not until 2023, when Siddaramaiah returned to power, that an order was issued tasking K. Jayaprakash Hegde, the then chairman of the Karnataka State Backward Classes Commission, to prepare a full report utilising data from the 2015 survey.

Hegde handed over his new report in February 2024 but it remained in its sealed boxes—till it was sprung on everyone at a cabinet meeting on April 11. The April 17 meeting was set to formally discuss its implementation but, amidst much gnashing of teeth, it remained inconclusive and a new date, May 2, has been set for the discussion. There are two theories about the problematic passage the report is facing even within the Congress government. One contains motives worthy of a political thriller.

This more dramatic script focuses on the fact that the report's unveiling coincides with Siddaramaiah completing two years of his second tenure. From the start, it's been a stint defined by his rivalry with deputy D.K. Shivakumar, who has been biding time for a shot at the top job. Talk of a mid-term change-of-guard has been one of the enduring intrigues in Karnataka, giving rival parties ample chance to target it. "The CM uses the caste census as a distraction whenever his chair is under threat," said the BJP's R. Ashoka, Leader of the Opposition in the assembly, in a post on X.

That April 16 post also reeled off a volley of 12 posers on the report, which Ashoka termed "unscientific". He also pointed out that Shivakumar, a Vokkaliga, was a signatory to a 2023 demand by a caste body, the Rajya Vokkaligara Sangha (RVS), to reject the report. Like other Vokkaliga leaders, he implied, Shivakumar will be answerable to the community. That he went into a huddle with party MLAs ahead of the April 17 meeting, and that it stayed inconclusive, did not disprove that line.

THE WELFARIST LOGIC

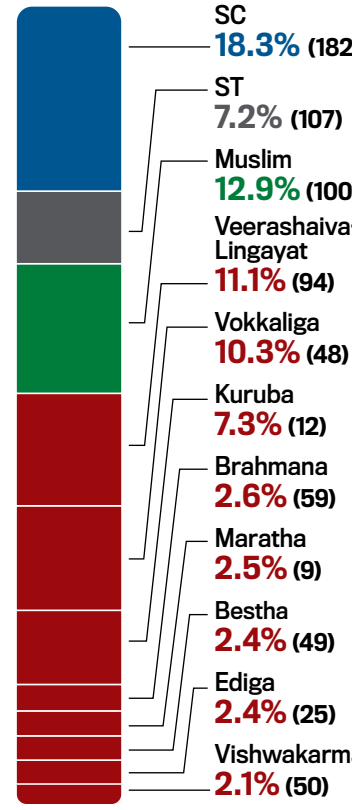
The other theory is more anodyne. The caste census has been a key plank of the Congress in recent times—Rahul Gandhi, Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, is now one of its chief votaries. Building up momentum around the theme, Bihar had released its own caste survey in October 2023. Congress-ruled Telangana came out with its own census in February 2024. In fact, during the recent All India Congress Committee meeting at Ahmedabad, Telangana chief minister A. Revanth Reddy came in for praise for the accomplishment. The caste census was also a key promise in the Congress manifesto for the 2023 Karnataka assembly election. By this token, Siddaramaiah had procrastinated for a year, and had little choice but to table the long-pending report now.

Karnataka has a long history of seeking to assess community-specific markers of socio-economic progress and working those into affirmative action. The princely state of Mysore was among the pioneers of backward class reservation. A committee set up by Maharaja Krishnaraja Wadiyar IV recommended in 1921 that all communities other than Brahmins should be regarded as backward. In the past 50 years, there have been three committee reports that guided the state's backward quotas: the Havanur report of 1975, the T. Venkataswamy report of 1986 (which was rejected), and the Justice O. Chinnappa Reddy report of 1990. However, in 1994, the Karnataka government formulated a reservation policy that exceeded the 50 per cent cap set by the Supreme Court, and therefore had to be revised following a legal challenge. Thus evolved a categorisation of backward classes into five groups that is still being followed. The categories—I, IIa, IIb, IIIa and IIIb—account for 32 per cent reserva-

Some have not missed the fact that the report release comes ahead of the half-way mark of Sidda's tenure, when he was 'slated' to cede his chair to DKS

THE NEW DATA

The KSES 2024 report, based on data gleaned from a 54-point questionnaire, has rejigged some key caste group numbers in Karnataka



Numbers denote % of population; No. of sub-castes in ( ); above 2% of population considered

Graphic by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY